

Syllabus

Econ 309-D01, Economic Problems and Public Policies
Summer 2026
Asynchronous

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Office Hours by Appointment (online over Zoom)
I am usually free in the mornings or evenings during the week

COURSE OBJECTIVES AND LEARNING OUTCOMES:

This course aims to help you think like an economist when discussing public policy issues. It does this by intuitively applying fundamental economic principles to a variety of contemporary public policy issues. Economics is not just about money, the stock market, or business. It is a way of analyzing *all forms* of human decision-making—from profit-seeking to charity.

This class encourages you to challenge many conventional wisdoms. Its approach will teach you to detect and correct fallacious economic reasoning and expose common economic myths. By the end of the course, your capacity to observe your surroundings through the lens of economics will improve. As a result, so will your appreciation for how the world works.

COURSE MATERIALS:

There are two required books for this course:

Caleb Fuller. 2021. [*No Free Lunch: Six Economic Lies You've Been Taught And Probably Believe*](#). Freiling Publishing

Roger Miller, Daniel Benjamin, Douglass North. 2018. [*The Economics of Public Issues, 20th ed.*](#) Pearson.

All other readings are available online and free of charge. A hyperlink is included in the title of each reading listed below.

This course requires Honorlock. Please read about Honorlock and download it here:
<https://its.gmu.edu/knowledge-base/honorlock-for-students/>

TENTATIVE SCHEDULE

(Subject to change at my discretion – all changes will be announced online)

1. The Economic Approach

1. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Introduction
2. Russell Roberts. “[A Marvel of Cooperation: How Order Emerges without a Conscious Planner](#)”
3. Paul Heyne. “[Economics as a Way of Thinking](#)”
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 1-5

2. Property, Trade, Coordination, and Institutions

1. Armen Alchian, “[Property Rights.](#)”
2. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 1
3. Video: [Thomas Thwaites—How I Built a Toaster From Scratch](#)
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 6-10

3. The Market Process

1. Russell Roberts. “[The Reality of Markets](#)”
2. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 2
3. Video: [Chris Coyne: The Market Process](#)
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 11-14

4. The Economic of Politics

1. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 3
2. Russell Roberts. “[Pigs Don’t Fly: The Economic Way of Thinking About Politics.](#)”
3. Video: [Geoffrey Brennan: What is Public Choice Theory?](#)
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 15-18

5. Midterm exam June 23

6. The Rule of Law, Regulation, and Development

1. John Cochrane. 2015. "[The Rule of Law in the Regulatory State](#)" (pp. 5-13 of pdf)
2. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 4
3. Video: [Regulatory Capture](#)
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 19-24

7. Economic Sanctions

1. Kimberly Ann Elliott, Gary Clyde Hufbauer, and Barbara Oegg. "[Sanctions](#)," *The Concise Encyclopedia of Economics*.
2. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 5
3. NPR Planet Money, "[Do Sanctions Work?](#)"
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 25-28, and [Protection or Free Trade](#) by Henry George *pages 37-48*

8. Economic Nationalism, Development, and Foreign Intervention

1. Frederic Bastiat. "[A Petition](#)"
2. Caleb Fuller, *No Free Lunch*, Chapter 6
3. Douglas Irwin, "[Tariffs](#)"
4. Miller, Benjamin, and North, Chapters 29-31

9. Economic and Politics, Reflections and Questions

1. James Buchanan [What Should Economists do?](#)
2. James Buchanan, "[Order is defined in the process of its emergence](#)"
3. J. H. Clapham, "[Of Empty Economic Boxes](#)"

10. Final exam July 24

COURSE STRUCTURE & GRADING:

Lectures will be posted periodically to discuss the books and readings. Students are expected to have completed the necessary readings. Take notes while watching the lectures—otherwise you will zone out. Email me any questions you have regarding the content or information.

Your final grade is based on written reading checks, an in-person midterm and final, and a term paper.

1. Reaction essays: 30%
2. Midterm: 30%
3. Final exam: 40%

Reflection essays:

A reflection essay is due at the end of each week. These assignments will use Honorlock to ensure your answers are your own. Your reflection essays should focus on what you learned in the unit and what your thoughts are on the unit.

The essays should be around 400-500 words. As long as you are able to roughly summarize the material covered in the week and reflect on your thoughts related to the material, you should receive a 10/10.

Midterm:

I will announce what material the midterm will cover. Content covered in the lectures and readings are fair game. The format will be multiple choice with short and long answer questions.

Honorlock will be used for the midterm.

Final exam:

The final exam is comprehensive and will include *all* material covered throughout the semester. The format will be multiple choice with short and long answer questions.

Exam content will include the material covered in class and in the assigned readings. This means that anything that I cover in lectures is subject to being on the exams, even if it is not in the assigned readings.

Honorlock will be used for the final.

GRADING SCALE:

Final grades will be assigned as follows:

A+ 98-100; A 92-97; A- 90-91; B+ 88-89; B 82-87; B- 80-81; C+ 78-79; C 72-77; C- 70-71; D 60-69; F Below 60

I do round up (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 71.5 you have earned a C for the course), but I do not raise grades upon request (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 87 you have earned a B for the course, not a B+).

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CLASS SUCCESS:

Asynchronous classes are difficult. To succeed in this class, I recommend taking short notes that condense what you have learned from each page or section as you read. Doing so will help you retain the information and study for the exams. As you read, write down any questions or confusions you have. If the course material is difficult to understand, use an AI like ChatGPT to help you. If the questions or confusions, please schedule a time to meet with me via Zoom. Don't be afraid to schedule office hours! I'm always happy to meet if you want to have a relaxed conversation about economics, related to the class or otherwise.

SPECIAL ACCOMMODATIONS:

If you require any special accommodations, please reach out to me so that we can work together to make sure that you have what you need to succeed in this course. Please bring [appropriate paperwork](#) from the University.

AI POLICY

I highly recommend using AI (such as ChatGPT) to answer any questions or confusions you may have before bringing them to me. AI is a great tool that can supplement your learning—but it cannot replace it. Use AI to help explain difficult concepts, but do not use it to skip the readings. Keep in mind that AI is often wrong and it is just a predictive algorithm of what letter is the best next option. You will know that you understand a concept when you can explain it to someone else (in real life or by writing a paragraph to an imaginary curious mind). AI can help you get to become proficient, but only if you don't use it as a crutch.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY:

It is expected that students adhere to the George Mason University Academic Standards as it relates to integrity regarding coursework and grades. The Academic Standards reads as follows: “As members of the George Mason University community, we are committed to fostering an environment of trust, respect, and scholarly excellence. Our academic standards are the

foundation of this commitment, guiding our behavior and interactions within this academic community. The practices for implementing these standards adapt to modern practices, disciplinary contexts, and technological advancements. Our standards are embodied in our courses, policies, and scholarship, and are upheld in the following principles:

- **Honesty:** Providing accurate information in all academic endeavors, including communications, assignments, and examinations.
- **Acknowledgement:** Giving proper credit for all contributions to one's work. This involves the use of accurate citations and references for any ideas, words, or materials created by others in the style appropriate to the discipline. It also includes acknowledging shared authorship in group projects, co-authored pieces, and project reports.
- **Uniqueness of Work:** Ensuring that all submitted work is the result of one's own effort and is original, including free from self-plagiarism. This principle extends to written assignments, code, presentations, exams, and all other forms of academic work.

Violations of these standards—including but not limited to plagiarism, fabrication, and cheating—are taken seriously and will be addressed in accordance with university policies. The process for reporting, investigating, and adjudicating violations is outlined in the university's procedures. Consequences of violations may include academic sanctions, disciplinary actions, and other measures necessary to uphold the integrity of our academic community.

The principles outlined in these academic standards reflect our collective commitment to upholding the highest standards of honesty, acknowledgement, and uniqueness of work. By adhering to these principles, we ensure the continued excellence and integrity of George Mason University's academic community." More information can be found [here](#).

Further information on Mason Course Policies are available [here](#).